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Charcoal and wood extraction are threats to Luwero, Uganda's agroforestry systems

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Luwero Uganda is home to many ethnic groups with diverse cultures and diverse agroforestry systems that provide livelihoods to local communities. Luwero, though just over 60 kilometres north of Uganda's capital city of Kampala, is home to both rich and fragile biodiversity, with several forest reserves and wetlands. These are supported by the surrounding agroforestry systems which act as a buffer while also providing year-round food supply. However, Luwero also has high levels of poverty. The markets of Kampala are a major draw for products from Luwero, leading to the cutting of trees for firewood, charcoal and timber and clearing of land for commercial agricultural plantations (mainly pineapple).

We sought to better understand the trends and drivers of loss of agroforestry systems in Luwero. We carried out fieldwork in Luwero through focus group discussions with community members and farmers together with local officials. These experts identified weak rules and legislation together with a lack of effort for replanting trees as the main drivers of deforestation. Good roads and communication have also led to the loss of trees across agroforestry systems of the region. These experts identified interventions to stop the loss of tree cover in the region, including introducing affordable alternatives to firewood and charcoal (i.e. briquettes, solar cookers) and promotion of alternative sources of income to charcoal burning. They further identified the need to raise awareness about the importance of trees and the dangers of clearing trees. They pointed out the need for stronger rules to deter deforestation activities as well as promotion of agroforestry-reforestation (i.e. give tree seedlings to farmers and offering technical support to follow up with these farmers and give advice). Interventions to promote the importance of agroforestry and planting trees could sensitize communities to the issue and help Luwero maintain tree cover.